

THE TEXT

14 What good is it, my brothers and sisters, if someone claims to have faith but has no deeds? Can such faith save them? **15** Suppose a brother or a sister is without clothes and daily food. **16** If one of you says to them, "Go in peace; keep warm and well fed," but does nothing about their physical needs, what good is it? **17** In the same way, faith by itself, if it is not accompanied by action, is dead. **18** But someone will say, "You have faith; I have deeds." Show me your faith without deeds, and I will show you my faith by my deeds. **19** You believe that there is one God. Good! Even the demons believe that, and shudder. **20** You foolish person, do you want evidence that faith without deeds is useless? **21** Was not our father Abraham considered righteous for what he did when he offered his son Isaac on the altar? **22** You see that his faith and his actions were working together, and his faith was made complete by what he did. **23** And the scripture was fulfilled that says, "Abraham believed God, and it was credited to him as righteousness," and he was called God's friend. **24** You see that a person is considered righteous by what they do and not by faith alone. **25** In the same way, was not even Rahab the prostitute considered righteous for what she did when she gave lodging to the spies and sent them off in a different direction? **26** As the body without the spirit is dead, so faith without deeds is dead.

SAY THESE

Read it whole. No commentary,
no annotation while reading.

Let it sit for a beat afterward.

THE DIFFICULTY

JAMES 2:24

"a person is considered righteous by what they do
and **not by faith alone**"

same words, opposite things

both reach for **Abraham** to prove it

both quote **the same verse** about Abraham, Gen 15:6

Luther: *epistle of straw*, wanted it out of the canon

PAUL · ROMANS 3:28

"a person is justified **by faith apart from** the
works of the law"

SAY THESE

"I am not going to soften it,
because everybody softens it
and you can always tell."

"Those are not two shades of
emphasis."

"This is not a manufactured
problem invented by people
looking for trouble. It split the
church."

"If your answer is that the
tension is only apparent and we
should all calm down, you have
not felt the problem yet."

draw the collision, 2:24 ↔ Rom 3:28

THE TURN

2:19 "You believe that there is one God. Good! Even the demons believe that, and shudder."

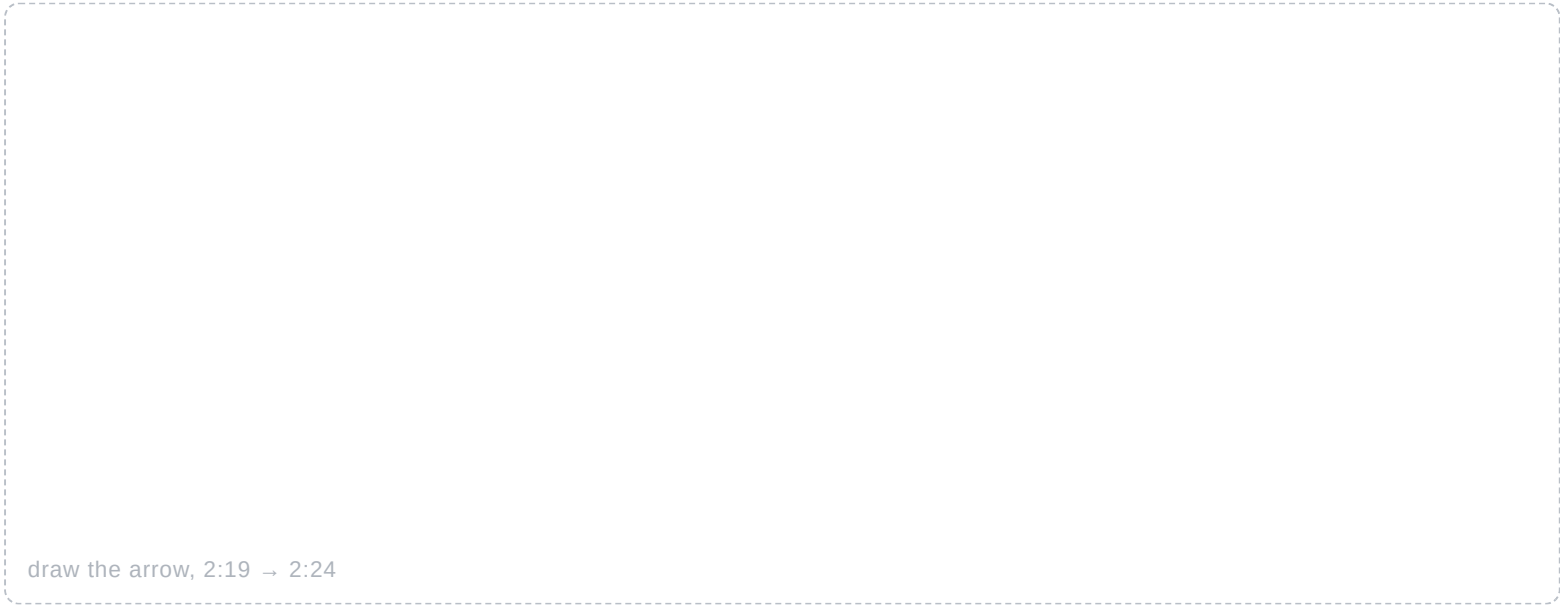
the **Shema**, Deut 6:4 · said twice a day · bedrock of the religion
the single most correct sentence a human being can say
theology exact, not approximate. they are not guessing.

2:24, "FAITH ALONE"

= the faith of **2:19**
assent. signing the proposition.

PAUL · GAL 5:6

"faith expressing itself through love"
trust that acts. works already inside.



SAY THESE

"Almost nobody reads verse 24 in the light of verse 19."

"Sit on what he just did."

"He reaches for the best creed available to a Jew. And he hands it to demons."

"Their theology is better than yours."

DOES THE OTHER WORD HOLD UP?

JAMES · WORKS

2:16 clothe the naked, feed the hungry
2:25 Rahab hides the spies, sends them out safe
1:27 orphans and widows in their distress
every one a mercy done to a body

PAUL · WORKS OF THE LAW

circumcision
food laws
sabbath
calendar
every one a Torah boundary marker, Jew from Gentile

Paul asks: what makes a Gentile a member of the people of God
James asks: whether the faith you claim is alive

two circles, then the gap between them

SAY THESE
"If faith is two different objects, works had better be too, or the fix is half a fix."

"Watch what James counts as a work. Every single time he gives an example."

"Different questions, different objects, same English word twice over."

Perfect belief. Zero communion.

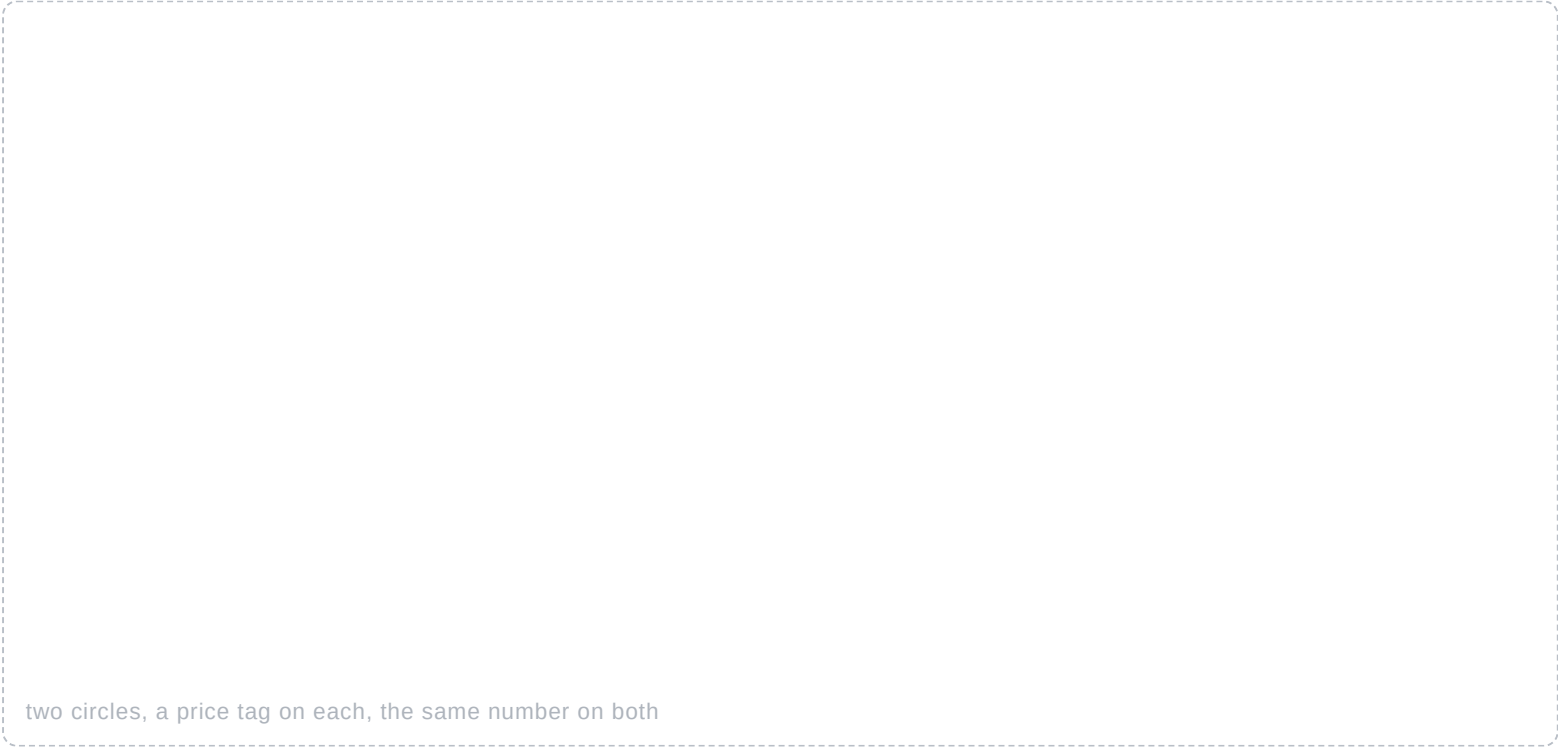
THEN WHY THESE TWO WITNESSES?

ABRAHAM · 2:21

the founding insider
patriarch, father of the nation
the most respectable name a Jew can say

both "**considered righteous for what they did**"
same verdict, same breath, priced identically

nothing comparable to weigh between them



RAHAB · 2:25

the total outsider
foreign, a woman, a Canaanite, a prostitute
no lineage, no standing, no patron, no ring

SAY THESE
"If works meant earning, that pairing is insane."

"In the language of last episode, a person with no face the world would receive."

"And notice what he does inside his own proof."

THE SAME VERSE, TWO DAYS

Gen 15:6 "Abraham believed God, and it was credited to him as righteousness"

quoted by both men

PAUL READS IT WHERE IT SITS

Genesis 15, the night of the stars

before Isaac

before circumcision

Rom 4, the whole point is the timing

JAMES READS IT FORWARD

Genesis 22, the knife on the mountain

thirty years later

2:22-23 "made complete" / "was fulfilled"

SAY THESE

"They are quoting it about two different days."

"And listen to his verbs."

"The faith that was real at fifteen is the faith that walked up the hill at twenty-two."

"One life, filmed at two moments, by two men who each needed a different frame."

one timeline, mark 15 and 22, thirty years between

THE LANDING

2:26 "As the body without the spirit is dead, so faith without deeds is dead."

nekra a corpse

not weak. not immature. not incomplete.

1:18 "he chose to give us birth through the word of truth"

chose, and birth

SAY THESE

"That analogy is not moral, it is ontological."

"It has the shape of the living thing exactly, every feature in the right place, and it is the opposite of the living thing."

"Here is what I want to leave on you, because it is the thing that has bothered me all week."

"There is only one instrument James gives you."

"That is not a comfortable place to end and I am not going to pretend otherwise."

Perfect belief. Zero communion.

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